Activity 2 — Attitude and Positive Language at a Changi Airport Service Counter

Topic	2 — Establishing Your Service Attitude
Mapping	LO1 · Apply service attitude, body language and positive language under pressure.
Format	Role Play + Peer Sharing
Duration	15 minutes
Roles	Pairs. Role A = Service Officer, Role B = Mr Krishnan. Swap after the first round. Observers score.

The Scenario

Changi Airport Terminal 3, airline transfer desk, 11:40pm. Mr Krishnan and his two children (aged 4 and 7) have missed their connecting flight to Chennai because the inbound flight was delayed by weather. The next available flight is 14 hours away. Company policy for weather delays: no hotel accommodation, no meal vouchers, rebooking only. The children are crying. Mr Krishnan has been queueing for 35 minutes and is the eleventh passenger you have seen with the same problem tonight. You are 90 minutes past the end of your shift.

What you CAN do: rebook him on the 1:50pm flight; give him lounge access at your discretion; provide a transit hotel booking form at his own cost; escalate to the duty manager for a goodwill exception.

What You Will Produce

A rewritten positive-language script and a 5-minute role play that delivers a 'no' without losing the customer.

Materials: Positive language worksheet · Observer checklist.

Discussion Questions

1. Rewrite each phrase in positive language: 'We don't cover weather delays.' / 'There's nothing I can do.' / 'You'll have to pay for that yourself.' / 'That's not our policy.' / 'I don't know.'

2. You are 90 minutes past your shift end and this is the eleventh identical case. How does that show up in your body language and voice, even when your words are correct?

3. The answer to 'will you pay for my hotel?' is genuinely no. How do you say no and still leave the customer feeling served?

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4. What can you offer that costs the company little but changes how Mr Krishnan experiences this? Name three things.

5. At what point, if any, would you escalate to the duty manager — and what would you say to Mr Krishnan as you do it?

6. The two crying children are not your customer, but they change the interaction. How?

Step-by-Step

1. Individually, rewrite the five negative phrases from discussion question 1 into positive language. Write both versions side by side so the contrast is visible.

2. Compare with your partner. Keep the strongest rewrite of each pair. A good rewrite states what you CAN do and never begins with 'unfortunately' or 'we don't'.

3. Assign roles: A = Service Officer, B = Mr Krishnan. B, read only the customer half of the brief — you are exhausted, your children are crying, and you believe the airline owes you a hotel.

4. Before starting, A checks their own physical setup: shoulders back, hands visible, eye contact ready, a breath in before the first word. This is the attitude reset from Topic 2.

5. Run the role play for 5 minutes. A must deliver the 'no' on hotel accommodation within the first 2 minutes — do not delay it to seem helpful, that is worse.

6. Observers mark the checklist: Did A greet and acknowledge within seconds? Did A acknowledge the children? Did A use positive language? Did A offer alternatives before being asked? Did A state clear next steps?

7. Debrief in the pair for 2 minutes: B says how the 'no' actually felt to receive, which is the only score that matters.

8. Swap roles and run the scenario again. The second Officer must use at least two techniques they saw work in round one.

Debrief — What a Strong Answer Looks Like

- Positive language does not mean saying yes. It means directing the customer to what IS available: 'I can get you on the 1:50pm and into the lounge now' beats 'we don't cover weather delays' with the same underlying answer.
- 'I don't know' becomes 'let me find out' — the second is the same information plus ownership.
- Fatigue leaks through the non-verbal channel first. Words stay professional long after tone and posture have given up. Observers should watch for flat tone, no eye contact, and a sigh before speaking.

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- The three low-cost offers most groups find: lounge access (comfort for the kids), a proactive rebooking done before he asks, and a printed confirmation so he does not have to re-explain at the next desk.
- Acknowledge the children explicitly — the customer's stress is mostly about them. Serving the parent means noticing the kids.
- Escalation here is not defeat: naming the duty manager and saying 'I want to ask if we can make an exception for you' shows the customer you are on their side of the counter.

Check Your Work

You delivered a genuine 'no' inside 2 minutes, offered at least two alternatives unprompted, and your partner reports feeling served rather than dismissed.

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